



YOU ARE **18 WEEKS AND 6 DAYS**

148 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Your baby appears to be quite thin on early scans. One reason is that fat reserves have not yet been laid down underneath the skin, which looks almost transparent. An ultrasound image also highlights the underlying bony skeleton, enhancing this effect.

“At around this time you’ll have another scan, and your baby will get a thorough health checkup.”

From 18–20 weeks most doctors’ offices or hospitals offer a detailed ultrasound scan, which is termed an “anatomy” scan. The scan is used to check the baby’s overall development and examine the organs and body systems (see [Your 20-week scan](#)) to check for signs of problems. For most women and their partners, this scan will reassure them that all is progressing well with the baby’s development.

The scan can take some time to perform because of the detailed measurements and investigations taking place. The sonographer can do the checks only when the baby is in the correct position—this can be a challenge, given that the baby is likely to be moving around a lot. If the position of your baby makes it difficult to do all the checks, you may be asked to walk around for a little while and then return, or even to come back in a week or two for another attempt.

EXERCISING IN WATER

It’s great to work out in water during pregnancy: the added support for your belly and extra resistance will enable you to maintain your fitness and tone. When standing, the water should be just above your waist with your knees slightly bent—too deep and you will not be stable enough; too shallow and you won’t get enough support from the water.

- **Running in place:** bring your knees up to just below your waist and push your arms forward and back in a pumping motion under the water. Jog for 3 to 4 minutes, if possible, but always stop if you feel tired. This exercise has cardiovascular benefits, is a great warm up, and will help tone your legs and arms.
- **Bicycle exercise:** stand in the water and place a float under each arm. Lean back slightly and move your legs in front of you, as if you are rotating the pedals on a bicycle. Continue the cycling motion for 3 to 4 minutes, if possible, but always stop if you start feeling tired. This exercise will help you maintain your fitness and help tone your legs. It’s also a good way to strengthen your back and arms. Stop if you feel any pain in your back or abdomen.